

Reserved by Jumper, Missed by the Tally

Cataloguing How Informal Picnic-Table Claims Escape Facilities' Sit-and-Count Tally

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Background

Facilities counts a picnic table “in use” only if someone is sitting at it when the quarterly walkthrough passes. Staff and students claim tables with jumpers, laptops, and bags for far longer than they occupy them. Does the tally see any of it?

Aims

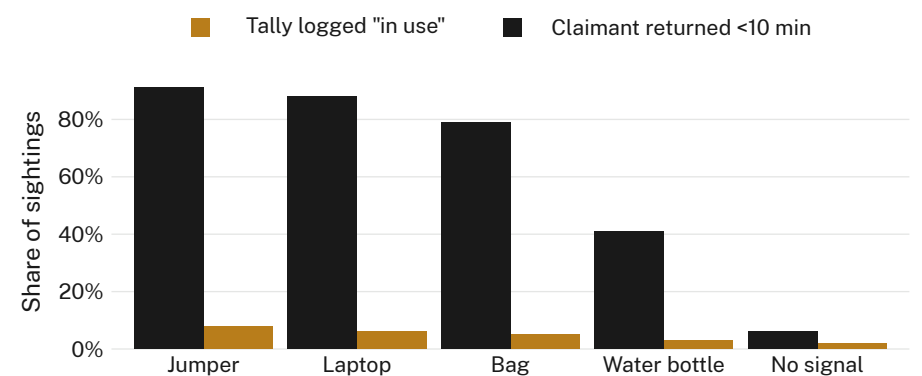
- Catalogue the informal signals staff and students use to claim a picnic table before sitting down
- Test whether each signal type predicts the claimant's return within a fixed window
- Compare signal-predicted claims against Facilities' quarterly walkthrough tally

Methods

- 58 tables · 14 clusters outside the library and refectory · 2-minute time-lapse photography, 8am-6pm · one 12-week term
- Claim-signal taxonomy (jumper, laptop, bag, water bottle, none) coded independently by two raters, checked against return within 10 minutes
- Tally walkthrough times logged separately and not disclosed to coders in advance

Results

A draped jumper or a mid-charge laptop predicted the claimant's return within ten minutes in the large majority of sightings; the quarterly tally logged the same table as “in use” in only a small minority of those instances.



Across 412 coded sightings between March and June 2026, a jumper predicted return within ten minutes 91% of the time and a laptop 88%, while the walkthrough tally logged either table as “in use” in under one sighting in ten.

Discussion & conclusions

The tally isn't wrong about what it counts, only about what an empty seat usually means. A table read as slack capacity by the walkthrough was, on the taxonomy's own evidence, claimed the whole time, and a water bottle alone was the one signal weak enough to sometimes agree with the tally's reading. Any furniture-removal decision keyed to the walkthrough inherits that blind spot at the point it matters most, the table Facilities is about to take away. The taxonomy travels: the same four signals were legible to both raters at every cluster, from the busiest table by the library steps to the quietest one behind the refectory bins. Next: a removal decision keyed to a claim signal, not just a seated body, before a table leaves the yard.

References

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Time-lapse frames retained as aggregate counts only; no individual claimant identified.

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